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The Politics of Sports

It is common knowledge that the international sports calendar is fixed years in advance to give every participating nation the opportunity to prepare for them, whether it is to train athletes or for the host country to set up the required infrastructure. The New Delhi Commonwealth Games 2010 was not the best example of either.

India's hosting of this sporting extravaganza led to an unfortunate chain of events, starting with charges of large-scale corruption in the organization of the Commonwealth Games against certain people, who were subsequently jailed because of these charges, and eventually ending in the International Olympic Committee (IOC) suspending the Indian Olympic Association in December 2012. What this means is that unless India is readmitted by the IOC, no Indian athlete can compete at future Olympic Games.

For sports to flourish in India, drastic measures need to be urgently taken. There has to be a unanimous agreement between the government, sports federations and associations, to discard personal agendas and gains and strive towards a common goal. The government has provided more than adequate funds and several state-of-the-art facilities, but what are they getting in return? Hard-hitting questions need to be asked: what are the plans for the future? What has been done to implement them? Have funds been honestly disbursed? It is only when these questions have been debated and answered should funds be allocated.

Many initiatives can be taken if we want standards to improve. But, first there must be a desire to change the system. Our one-point agenda should be to groom sportspeople to succeed in national and international